All the aforementioned orders and many similar ones had to be implemented. The worst part was that there was no one who could stand up to the home secretary. This was the state of affairs prior to Kiran's joining as the IGP, Chandigarh. The former IGP, Ram Pal Singh, had given up after his protests made no difference whatsoever! He admitted: 'No one listened to me, hence I had no choice but to let her [the home secretary] do what she wanted.' The home secretary tried to do the same with Kiran. She ordered the suspension of gazetted and non-gazetted police officers and leaked the information to the press even before Kiran was informed. The home secretary was on an extended tenure, giving the impression that she was indispensable, particularly in view of the impending general elections as she was also the chief electoral officer. Various police officers and others complained that she was despotic in her behaviour and brooked no questioning. She obviously had the establishment on her side, whereas Kiran was new to her job and was still to build bridges with her colleagues and yet to know the officials and seniors outside her department. In the first few weeks, her priority, unlike that of many others, was putting her house in order before she could get on to the social circuit.

The home secretary attacked Kiran where it hurt the most. She ordered the suspension of two deputy superintendents of police and one inspector besides some other staff. Orders went to them directly yet again, with the media being informed. As IG of the Chandigarh Police Force, Kiran learnt of the suspension through the distraught officers and the newspapers. The basis of the suspension was an enquiry instituted by the home secretary on 16 February 1999 during the tenure of Kiran's predecessor. (It may be recalled that Kiran had joined Chandigarh Police on 5 April 1999.)

The genesis of the enquiry was a newspaper report of missing files on two terrorist acts that had taken place in 1983 and 1984. During those years, terrorism was at its peak in Punjab, including Chandigarh. On the basis of news reports, the district senior superintendent of police, C. S. R. Reddy, had ordered the city superintendent of police, Baldev Singh, to conduct an enquiry and submit his report. The latter went ahead and managed to recover the relevant files. But without waiting for the enquiry to be completed and without consulting the IGP, the home secretary ordered another enquiry of her own. This enquiry was completed but without the following inputs:

- The statement of the then SSP C. S. R. Reddy who was at the helm of affairs and was in the know of the matter. He had been there for a number of years and had had various opportunities to conduct police inspections.

- The statement and conclusion drawn by the SP who had conducted the enquiry, nearly completed it and even recovered the files from the same police station.

- The statements of various other important functionaries, including the IGP, who were in a position to know what could have happened.

Kiran was not informed of any such pending enquiry at the time of her taking charge of the city police. But once she was informed of the *fait accompli*, she set about her task and analysed all the details herself. She pleaded with the powers that be. When that did not help, she sought an appointment to meet the administrator, Chandigarh, to plead further. She gave him a written note enlisting the reasons, duly verified, why she thought the suspension of officers was inappropriate. This is what she presented before the final judge: